

Joseon Moon Jar

A short comparative object brief using public museum records

Region	Period	Method	Output
Korea	Late Joseon	Museum-record comparison	Brief + source trail

Question

What can be established quickly and reliably about the Korean object type commonly called the “moon jar,” and how can museum records frame a first-stage object inquiry?

Finding

The National Museum of Korea identifies moon jars as large round white-porcelain vessels of the Joseon dynasty and explains that the familiar form was produced by joining upper and lower hemispherical sections. Its curator material places the appearance of the type from the late seventeenth century into the mid-eighteenth century. The Metropolitan Museum of Art catalogues a comparable example to the second half of the eighteenth century.

The museum records also make an important research distinction possible: the chronology of the ceramic form is not the same as the chronology of the modern name. National Museum of Korea material states that the jars were not nicknamed “moon jars” until the 1950s.

Research practice: separate object chronology, terminology, collection provenance, and later reception history. Each is a different evidentiary question.

Comparable museum records

Institution	Object / Date	Dimensions	Identifier
National Museum of Korea	White Porcelain Jar / Joseon Dynasty	H 41.0 cm	Treasure 1437; Jeopsu702
National Museum of Korea	White Porcelain Jar (Moon) / Joseon Dynasty	H 46.0 cm; mouth D 20.3 cm; base D 15.0 cm	Sinsu3658
The Metropolitan Museum of Art	Moon jar / second half 18th century	H 38.7 cm; D 33.0 cm; rim D 14.0 cm; base D 12.4 cm	1979.413.1

Research leads for a client-owned object

- Record exact measurements, profile photographs, base/foot, seam, glaze, firing marks, damage, repairs, labels, inscriptions, and packaging or sale records.
- Build a comparable set by dimensions, construction, period attribution, museum record, and documented history rather than visual resemblance alone.
- Separate documented ownership from claims, family stories, purchase recollections, or seller descriptions.
- Treat attribution, authentication, appraisal, and legal ownership questions as separate specialist tasks.

Sources

[National Museum of Korea - White Porcelain Jar, Treasure 1437](https://www.museum.go.kr/ENG/contents/E0403000000.do?relicId=941&schM;=view&searchId;=represent)

<https://www.museum.go.kr/ENG/contents/E0403000000.do?relicId=941&schM;=view&searchId;=represent>

[National Museum of Korea - White Porcelain Jar \(Moon\), Sinsu3658](https://www.museum.go.kr/ENG/contents/E0402000000.do?relicId=8586&schM;=view)

<https://www.museum.go.kr/ENG/contents/E0402000000.do?relicId=8586&schM;=view>

[National Museum of Korea - Curator's Picks: Joseon White Porcelain Moon Jars](https://www.museum.go.kr/ENG/contents/E0401000000.do?relicRecommendId=519669&schM;=view)

<https://www.museum.go.kr/ENG/contents/E0401000000.do?relicRecommendId=519669&schM;=view>

[The Metropolitan Museum of Art - Moon jar, 1979.413.1](https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/45432)

<https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/45432>

Client-version handoff

- 1-3 page synthesis memo with confirmed facts separated from open questions.
- Comparable-object table with accession numbers and direct institutional links.
- Research-lead list for archives, sale catalogues, publications, or provenance documents that merit a second pass.

Scope note

Demonstration sample prepared from public museum records. It shows research structure and source handling; it is not an authentication, appraisal, or complete catalogue entry.